



**Underlit greatness:** The success stories of boxers Nikhat Zareen and Lovlina Borgohain highlight a truth the numbers often miss. Women's excellence in India runs far beyond cricket, yet the reason it feels otherwise is simple. These sports rarely get the visibility that cricket does. THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY

Shafali Verma, who scored 87 and took two wickets in the World Cup final.

When Ashwani first opened his cricket academy in Rohtak for women in 2008, he had to visit homes to convince parents to let their daughters play. "At that time, women's cricket was still in its early years. Parents weren't even keen to let their daughters join my academy because they didn't feel comfortable that they would be playing alongside boys. I actually had to go to different states to scout players in that first year," he recalls.

Today, things are very different. "Every day, I have girls who want to join and play. I can't keep up right now because we are in the middle of the domestic season. We will only start taking children next year, and that's when you are going to see the real numbers."

This boom, Ashwani admits, will come at the expense of girls who might otherwise have chosen another sport. "Right now in India, we aren't at that stage where kids pick up sports because they enjoy it. A lot depends on what their parents choose. Like it or not, cricket is a far more glamorous sport than others. Parents can see that even the top 40

or 50 players in India will play the WPL, and they will be taken care of financially. How many other sports in India can say that their top 40 players have a future in the sport?

"Right now, when you see the money in cricket, the visibility, the fact that at least in Haryana this is a sport considered safe for girls, and the clear pathways for success, you can understand why parents want to put their daughters in cricket. Why would you want to see your child compete in a sport where the rewards don't match the struggle?" he says.

Indian women's cricket has already seen players switch from other sports (Jemimah Rodrigues represented Maharashtra's Under-17 hockey team and N. Shree Charani played badminton and ran track before taking up cricket), but none go the other way.

#### **Not the end of the world**

Not everyone believes the trend is inevitable. "I don't agree that money or career prospects are what motivate girls to choose a sport. When parents, especially in rural India, want to put their daughter in a sport, they usually pick something they have some connection to. If you

have some attachment to wrestling, then chances are you would first want your child to wrestle as well," says Olympic bronze medallist Sakshi Malik, now a coach and mother of a one-year-old daughter. "Apart from this, you will also see what sports facilities are near your home. If you are from a village in Haryana, chances are you will pick an akhara because that is what is accessible," she says.

Former table tennis Olympian Neha Aggarwal agrees. "Sport in India is extremely geographically coded. In the North East, kids will pick up boxing or football, or weightlifting. In rural Haryana, they will pick up wrestling or kabaddi. These sports are extremely popular at a local level.

"Moreover, I think India is big enough. We have 1.5 billion people. Women's cricket has been popular for a while now, but our girls have been improving their performance across sports steadily. We aren't stagnating. That shows that our population is more than enough to find talent. Everyone isn't going to go into cricket," says Aggarwal, who is also head of partnerships at Olympic Gold Quest.

Even if much of the talent gravitates towards cricket, hockey coach Pritam is not worried. "If you speak to a lot of male non-cricket athletes, they seem to carry a huge grudge against cricket because they feel they aren't being given their due, because cricket gets all the support. Maybe if I were a man, I might feel the same way, but I'm not. I don't think you will find many women sportspersons who are jealous of women's cricket. I'm very happy they are doing so well.

"When I hear about parents wanting to put their daughters into cricket, I don't see it as a loss for hockey. I see it as one more girl getting the chance to play any sport. Even now, there are so few girls who play sport in India. When it starts becoming normal for a girl to play sport, that is a win for me. Once women's sport is accepted in society, I am sure enough girls will choose other sports as well," she says.